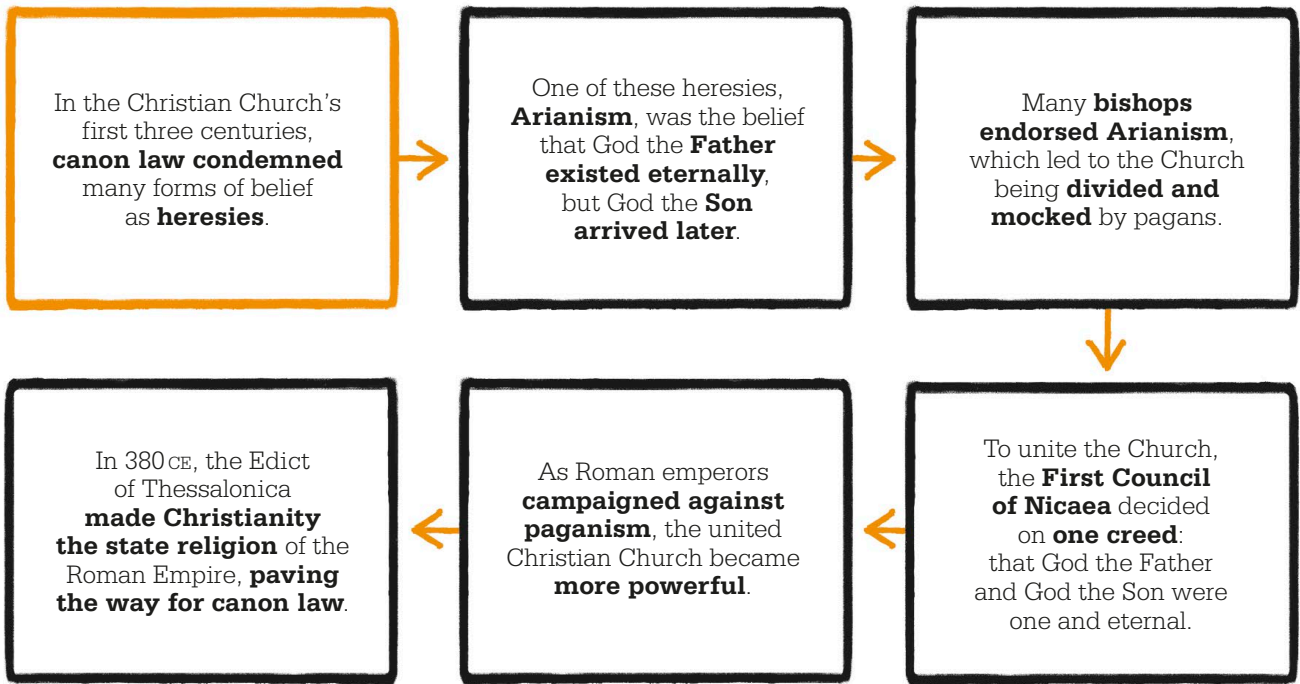


**See also:** The Ten Commandments and Mosaic law 20–23 ■ Aristotle and natural law 32–33 ■ The Koran 54–57 ■ Gratian's *Decretum* 60–63 ■ Thomas Aquinas 72–73



sects challenged this apostolic authority, the Church condemned their writings as heretical.

### Persecution of Christians

Christians refused to make sacrifices to Roman gods or the emperor and so, in the early years, most Romans viewed Christians with suspicion and hostility. They suffered a series of sporadic persecutions, beginning in 64 CE, under Emperor Nero. Despite this, by the 3rd century, Christians had become a visible minority throughout the empire, and the persecution increased dramatically.

In 250, Emperor Decius ordered everyone except Jews to make sacrifices to Roman gods or face death. Some Christians submitted and were called *lapsi* ("lapsed"). After the persecution ended, the Church had to decide whether the

lapsed could be readmitted. In 251, Bishop Cyprian of Carthage held a synod (council) of bishops, which ruled that the lapsed should be judged according to individual guilt. A second synod in Rome confirmed the ruling later that year. The Church was now deciding its law by a majority vote of bishops in synods. The greatest persecution took place under Emperor Diocletian in 303–305 and continued to a lesser extent for several years under his successor Galerius in the Eastern Roman (Byzantine) Empire (separated from the Western Empire in 285).

In the early 300s, 19 Spanish bishops held a synod at Elvira (now Granada in Spain), where they issued canons regulating the behavior of believers. One canon forbade baptized women from marrying Jews, pagans, or heretics.

Communion, even on the deathbed, was denied to anyone who sacrificed in a pagan temple and to adulterous wives. Bishops, priests, and deacons had to be celibate or they were removed from office. The canons of Elvira were binding only over churches that took part in the synod. The practice of permanent clerical celibacy spread to other churches in the Western Roman Empire, but it was interpreted more loosely in the Eastern Roman Empire, where priests were allowed to marry.

### The Edict of Milan

In 312, Constantine I, a recent convert to Christianity, became ruler of the Western Roman Empire. The following year, together with Eastern Roman Emperor Licinius, he issued the Edict of Milan, which for the first time gave freedom of worship to Christians. It also ordered the »